

## Understanding Your Operation: Laparoscopic Cholecystectomy

*What actually happens during gallbladder removal surgery.*

### Why Remove the Gallbladder?

Your gallbladder stores bile made by the liver and releases it to help digest fatty foods. When gallstones form or the gallbladder becomes inflamed, it can cause pain and other symptoms. A cholecystectomy removes the gallbladder entirely — it's one of the most common operations performed, and most people digest food normally afterward without it.

### Laparoscopic vs. Open Surgery

Laparoscopic (“keyhole”) surgery is the standard first approach: it uses several small incisions instead of one large one, which generally means less pain and a faster recovery. In a small number of cases, your surgeon may need to convert to an open procedure with a larger incision during the operation itself if that's safer for you — this is why patients typically consent to both approaches ahead of time.

### Step by Step: What Happens During Surgery

1. You're given general anesthesia, so you're fully asleep and feel nothing during the procedure.
2. The surgeon makes 3–4 small incisions in your abdomen, each about half an inch long.
3. Your abdomen is gently inflated with carbon dioxide gas to create room for the surgeon to work and see clearly.
4. A thin camera (laparoscope) is inserted through one incision so the surgical team can see inside on a monitor.
5. Specialized instruments, inserted through the other incisions, are used to carefully separate the gallbladder from the liver and the bile duct.
6. The gallbladder is removed through one of the small incisions.
7. The gas is released, and the incisions are closed with steri-strips, surgical glue, or sutures.

The operation itself typically takes about 30–90 minutes, though your surgeon may take more or less time depending on your anatomy.

### What Changes Afterward

Without a gallbladder, bile flows directly from the liver into the intestine instead of being stored and released in concentrated amounts. Most people digest food normally, though some notice looser stools — especially after fatty meals — in the weeks after surgery. This usually settles over time.

### Risks to Be Aware Of

Laparoscopic cholecystectomy is common and generally low-risk, but as with any surgery, there are possible complications, including:

- Bleeding or infection
- Injury to the bile duct or nearby structures (uncommon)
- Need to convert to open surgery during the procedure
- Reactions to anesthesia

Your surgeon will discuss how these risks apply specifically to your health history.

## How Long You'll Be at the Hospital

Many patients go home the same day as surgery. Some stay one night for observation, depending on the surgeon's judgment and how the procedure goes — either outcome is normal.

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*This information is general education about a common procedure and does not replace advice from your own surgeon and care team. Instructions can vary by patient — always follow what your care team tells you, and call them with any questions or concerns.*